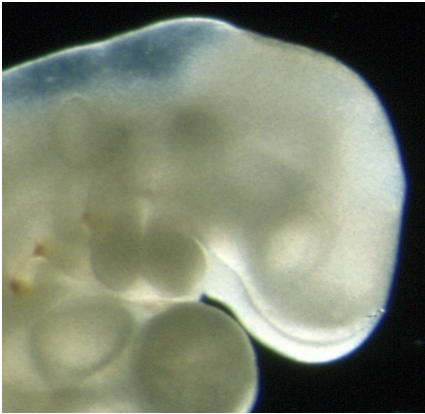




YOU ARE **5 WEEKS AND 2 DAYS**

243 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

The center of this image shows the baby's developing heart (darker gray), a very primitive structure at this stage. The baby's head is to the right of the image. The embryo is almost completely transparent.

“There won't be any visible signs of pregnancy on the outside for some time, but there are many changes taking place inside.”

At this early stage, all your unborn baby's needs will be met by the yolk sac. Attached to the embryo by a connecting stalk, this essential balloonlike structure indicates the site of your pregnancy and can usually be seen as early as this week as a sphere 0.1–0.2 in (3–4 mm) across. At first the yolk sac is as large as the disk of embryonic cells that will eventually become your baby.

Containing cells that perform a similar function to the liver, the yolk sac releases several pregnancy hormones and produces the embryo's first red blood cells. After week 9 the liver will take over these functions as the yolk sac gradually disappears and the placenta takes over, by around the 10th week of pregnancy.

Over the next seven days, a primitive circulatory system develops, well before any blood circulates to the placenta in the 10th week. And, by the end of this week, using the highest quality ultrasound equipment, it is just possible to see the embryo's heartbeat. At this early stage of pregnancy, the unborn baby's heart is simply a tube.